

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 38

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A construction worker steps out onto the topmost floor of an unfinished high-rise to fix a stubborn coupling, and is struck by the strange intimacy of seeing his city from above.

1

The lift cage opened at the forty-second floor with a tired metallic sigh, and I stepped out onto a floor that did not yet exist. There was concrete underfoot, certainly, and the cold ribs of rebar where the next pour would go, but no walls, no windows, no ceiling — only sky in every direction, and a wind that had not been invented at street level. The foreman had given me a single instruction at the morning briefing: the coupling on the east riser was leaking, and someone would have to go up and persuade it to behave. The someone, as so often, was me.

2

I checked the harness twice, because my father had checked his twice for forty years and was still alive to tell me about it. The webbing was clean, the buckles seated, the lanyard's snap-hook bright and stiff. I clipped onto the safety line that ran along the perimeter and felt the small, reassuring tug as the karabiner settled. Below me, through the gridded gaps in the formwork, the city showed itself in slices: a yellow taxi sliding under a flyover, the corrugated lid of a hawker centre, a primary-school field on which red and blue dots were arranging themselves into the morning's first assembly.

3

What surprises people, when they imagine working at this height, is the silence. Not silence in the strict sense — there is always the soft tick of cooling steel, the whine of a distant grinder, the periodic ping of the radio at my hip — but the absence of all the noises that a city, viewed from inside it, takes for granted. Up here, the horns and the brakes and the chatter have been filtered out by sheer altitude. The city becomes a thing you watch rather than a thing that watches you. I have, on occasion, caught myself talking aloud to no one, simply to test whether my own voice still belonged in this thin, careful air.

4

The leaking coupling was where the drawings had said it would be — a knuckle of brass and threaded steel where two lengths of pipe disagreed about how tightly they wished to be married. I knelt, set out my spanners in the order I would need them, and began. Twenty years of this work has taught me that hurry is the enemy. A bolt does not care that your shift ends at six; it tightens at its own pace, or it strips, and a stripped thread at this altitude is a problem one does not solve in a single afternoon.

5

Halfway through, I made the mistake of looking out instead of down. The horizon was very far away, and very flat, and for a moment my inner ear, which had been doing me the kindness of pretending I was on solid ground, remembered the truth. The floor tilted, although it had not moved. My hands knew, before my head did, to settle their grip on the spanner. I closed my eyes for the count of four, opened them, fixed them on the brass knuckle, and was, after another breath, a builder again rather than a man on a small concrete raft.

6

The coupling, when it finally gave up its argument, did so with a quiet click rather than a triumph. I watched a bead of water travel along the joint, hesitate, and vanish. I cycled the valve. I cycled it again. The leak, which had cost the foreman two days of irritation and a sub-contractor a small fortune in apologies, was simply no longer there. I sat back on my heels and allowed myself, for perhaps half a minute, the small private satisfaction that is the whole secret payment of skilled work.

7

From up here I could see the three estates my father had helped to raise in the 1970s, the school my daughter would walk to next year, and the long curve of the expressway that I had laid kerb-stones along as an apprentice. The city, from this angle, was not abstract. It was a map of the hours of my own life, and of the lives of men whose names I knew. I have never quite understood why builders are spoken of as though we were strangers to the places we build. We know them, I think, better than most.

8

I packed my tools, signed the coupling off on the radio, and made my way back to the lift cage. The wind pushed at my shoulders, not unkindly, the way an older colleague might. The doors closed. The numbers above the panel began to descend. By the time they reached the ground, I would be one more man in a yellow helmet crossing a car park; but for a few minutes, up there, I had been the only person in the city who could see the whole of it, and who had been trusted to make a small, quiet part of it work.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes the forty-second floor as “a floor that did not yet exist.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

2. The narrator says he was given a single instruction: to “persuade” the coupling to behave. What does the choice of the word **persuade** suggest about his attitude to his work? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says he “checked the harness twice, because my father had checked his twice for forty years and was still alive to tell me about it.” Explain how this sentence shows the narrator’s attitude to safety. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the noise at altitude as “silence... but not silence in the strict sense.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show the silence is not absolute. [2]

5. The narrator writes that “the city becomes a thing you watch rather than a thing that watches you.” Explain, in your own words, what this contrast suggests about his experience of the city from above. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes the pipes as having “disagreed about how tightly they wished to be married.” What is the **effect** of describing the pipes in this way? [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says, “my inner ear, which had been doing me the kindness of pretending I was on solid ground, remembered the truth.” Explain how the language used here makes his sense of vertigo feel sudden and disorientating. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator calls his half-minute of satisfaction “the whole secret payment of skilled work.” What does the word **secret** suggest about the rewards of his job? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator has a deep personal connection to the city he is helping to build. [1]

10. The narrator says that builders “know” the places they build “better than most.” What does this tell us about how he wants the reader to see his profession? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the promise and the peril of vertical urban farms.****1**

Step inside one of the newer vertical farms outside Singapore, Tokyo or Newark, and the first thing that strikes a visitor is the colour. Stack upon stack of leafy greens stretches towards a low ceiling, bathed in the magenta glow of energy-efficient LEDs tuned, with surgical precision, to the wavelengths that lettuce and basil prefer. No soil is in sight. No sun, either. The whole arrangement, depending on one's mood, looks either like the future of food or like an extremely expensive way to grow a salad.

2

The appeal of these farms is, on paper, considerable. Because the crops are grown indoors, in carefully sealed environments, they can be harvested every day of the year, regardless of monsoon, drought or cold snap. Because pests are excluded at the door, the use of pesticides falls to almost nothing. Because water is recirculated through hydroponic or aeroponic systems, the same head of lettuce that would take roughly two hundred and fifty litres of water to grow in an open field can be raised on less than five. In a region like Southeast Asia, where land is scarce and rainfall is becoming more erratic, those numbers are not trivial.

3

And yet the economics, on close inspection, remain stubbornly unconvincing. The single largest cost of a vertical farm is not seed, labour or rent, but electricity, and lighting plants twenty-four hours a day in air-conditioned premises is not cheap. Several heavily funded operators in the United States and Europe have, in the past three years, closed their doors or scaled back dramatically, citing energy bills they could not pass on to customers. The crops that pay back the lights are, for now, a narrow range — salad leaves, herbs, microgreens, some strawberries — none of which feed a population in the way that rice, wheat or potatoes do. A vertical farm will happily supply your restaurant's garnish; it will not, at present, supply your dinner.

4

The premium attached to the product is therefore not incidental. A pack of vertically farmed basil in a Singapore supermarket can cost two or three times the equivalent grown in soil. Defenders argue, fairly, that the comparison is unfair: the soil-grown basil has been flown in from Indonesia or trucked from Cameron Highlands, and the carbon and freshness costs of that journey are not on the price tag. Critics reply, equally fairly, that “true cost” arguments are difficult to put on a household budget. For most shoppers, what matters is what the till tells them, and what the till tells them, at present, is that lettuce in a stack is for someone else.

5

Where vertical farms may nonetheless earn their keep is in food security. Cities that import the bulk of their fresh produce — Singapore, Hong Kong, the Gulf states — discovered during the pandemic of the early 2020s, and again during subsequent shipping disruptions, that long supply chains are not always reliable supply chains. A modest, local capacity to grow leafy greens within the city itself is a hedge: it cannot replace overseas supply, but it can keep school canteens and hospital kitchens functioning when the borders close. The Singapore Food Agency has set a target that thirty per cent of the country's nutritional needs be produced locally by 2030; vertical farms, while only one piece of that puzzle, are an important piece.

6

Traditional farmers, predictably, are sceptical, and not without grounds. They point out that a system requiring constant electricity, computerised climate control and proprietary nutrient mixes is hardly the model of resilience its proponents claim. A power cut of a few hours, in a hot climate, can ruin an entire

crop. They add, with a touch of weariness, that “growing food without soil” has been promised as the next agricultural revolution at least three times in the last fifty years, and that the previous attempts have been quietly shelved when the venture capital ran out. There is some truth in this, even if it is not the whole truth.

7

What seems realistic, then, is neither the breathless techno-utopian vision nor the dismissive shrug. Vertical farms will probably not feed the world, and they will probably not disappear. They will continue, in the cities that can afford them, to produce a specific and modest set of crops — fresh, clean, local, and expensive — while the deeper questions of how to feed nine billion people remain, as they have always been, the province of soil, water and patient agronomy. The future of food is unlikely to be a single image. It may, more usefully, be a portfolio, in which the magenta-lit shelf is one shelf among many.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says a vertical farm looks either “like the future of food or like an extremely expensive way to grow a salad.” Explain, in your own words, what this contrast tells us about the writer’s **attitude** to vertical farms. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** environmental or practical advantages of vertical farming. [2]

14. The writer says that the water savings are “not trivial” in a region like Southeast Asia. Explain, in your own words, **why** these savings matter especially in that region. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says that the economics of vertical farming remain “stubbornly unconvincing.” What is the **effect** of the word **stubbornly** in this sentence? [2]

16. The writer says that “a vertical farm will happily supply your restaurant’s garnish; it will not, at present, supply your dinner.” Explain, in your own words, what this sentence means. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. Why does the writer describe the disagreement between defenders and critics of vertical farming as “equally fairly”? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. According to Paragraph 5, what specific lesson did cities like Singapore learn from the pandemic of the early 2020s? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. Traditional farmers say the claim that vertical farms are resilient is questionable. Give **two** reasons from Paragraph 6 that support their scepticism. [2]

20. The writer says there is “some truth in this, even if it is not the whole truth.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says the future of food may be “a portfolio, in which the magenta-lit shelf is one shelf among many.” Explain what is **effective** about the writer’s use of the word **portfolio** here. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the main advantages of vertical urban farms** and **the main difficulties they face**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Vertical urban farms offer several advantages, including ...

— END OF PAPER —